What Animals Can Teach Us

By Maria Mazziotti, Walt Whitman, Mary Oliver, John O'Donohue, Jacqueline Jaffee and Maryalicia Post

What Animals Teach Us by Maria Mazziotti

On the Discovery Channel, I watch a documentary on elephants set in sub-Saharan Africa. The mother has given birth to a calf who is weak and unable to stand. Every time the calf tries . . . her legs fold under her and her body sinks. The mother keeps trying to help the calf to stand, supporting the calf with her trunk . . . The announcer tells us another smaller elephant who joins the mother and the calf is the calf's older sister. She does not want to leave the mother and the calf alone. This is what animals teach us about family, these elephants so huge they could crush us

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in a minute; they teach us how to care for one another. The mother is trying repeatedly to get the calf to stand, until finally she is strong enough . . . to stand alone. Isn't this what we want for our children, to carry them and lift them until they are ready to stand on their own?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Maria Mazziotti Gillian
Book: Silence is an Empty House
ISBN: 978-1935520894
Publisher: NYQ Books
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2013

INTRODUCTION

This is a difficult time. As we continue our lives in ways we never thought possible – socially distanced, isolated, and coping with a pandemic; as we watch our nation struggle with the racial injustice we have yet to solve, and as conflicts are escalating into wars world-wide, there is a lesson to be learned. A lesson in humanity from a source we consider less than human. A lesson from the animals.

AA Milne once said . . . "Some people talk to animals. Not many listen though. That's the problem."

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What Animals Can Teach Us – A Collection including poems by Maria Mazziotti, Walt Whitman, Mary Oliver, John O'Donohue, Jacqueline Jaffee and Maryalicia Post

I Think I Could Turn And Live With Animals by Walt Whitman

I think I could turn and live with animals,
They do not sweat and whine about their condition,
They do not lie awake in the dark and weep for their sins,
Not one is dissatisfied, not one is demented with the mania
of owning things,
Not one kneels to another, nor to his kind that lived
thousands of years ago,
Not one is respectable or unhappy over the whole earth.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Walt Whitman
Book: Song of Myself
ISBN: 978-0486414102
Publisher: Dover Publications
Date (Month/Year): Feb 2001

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Straight Talk from a Fox by Mary Oliver

Listen says fox it is music to run
over the hills to lick
dew from the leaves to nose along
the edges of the ponds to smell the fat
ducks in their bright feathers but
far out, safe in their rafts of sleep.

It is music to wander the black back roads
outside of town no one awake or wondering
if anything miraculous is ever going to
happen, totally dumb to the fact of every
moment's miracle.

Don't think I haven't
peeked into windows. I see you in all your seasons,
arguing, talking about God
as if he were an idea instead of the grass,
instead of the stars. . .

What I am, and I know it, is

responsible, joyful, thankful. I would not

give my life for a thousand of yours.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Mary Oliver
Book: Red Bird, Pg 11
ISBN: 978-0807068939
Publisher: Beacon Press
Date (Month/Year): April 2009

To Learn From Animal Being by John O'Donohue

Nearer to the earth's heart,

Deeper within its silence:

Animals know this world

In a way we never will.

We who are ever

Distanced and distracted

By the parade of bright

Windows thought opens:

Their seamless presence

Is not fractured thus.

Stranded between time

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Gone and time emerging,

We manage seldom

To be where we are:

Whereas they are always

Looking out from

The here and now.

May we learn to return

And rest in the beauty

Of animal being,

Learn to lean low,

Leave our locked minds,

And with freed senses

Feel the earth

Breathing with us.

May we enter

Into lightness of spirit,

And slip frequently into

The feel of the wild.

Let the clear silence

Of our animal being

Cleanse our hearts

Of corrosive words.

May we learn to walk

Upon the earth

With all their confidence

And clear-eyed stillness

So that our minds

Might be baptized

In the name of the wind

And the light and the rain.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: John O'Donohue
Book: To Bless the Space Between Us, Pg 73-74
ISBN: 978-0385522274
Publisher: Doubleday
Date (Month/Year): March 2008

How Pets Teach Us Empathy by Jacqueline Jaffee

Perspective is everything
Our perspective defines our worldview
The way we were raised
The way we have been taught to see others.

Perspectives for some are stagnant
Even if they don't make sense
They remain the same

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Because of a refusal to listen.

Perspectives for others are fluid
For the open-minded, limits are boundless
Liberating
Insightful.

Human connection has long been
Something celebrated, something that is needed
At the core of humanity, and yet
It's still a profound obstacle in society.

How do we overcome this barrier?
This relentless cycle of division?
Of exclusivity?
How do we foster empathy?

We look to a second source.
We look to the companions that
Have been our friends for centuries
That have brought out the qualities that make us human.

When we welcome pets into
Our private space, our home
We learn kindness
We learn to care for someone else.

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When we give our pets food
Water and toys
A bed to sleep in
We learn to be attentive to someone else's needs.

When we give our pets love
Cuddle them when it storms
Scratch that spot just behind the ear
We learn compassion.

A pet teaches us so much
Morality, the way we want to be treated
The way we should treat others
And the relationships that spring from reciprocated love.

If we could all
Open our hearts to each other
In the same way we open our hearts to pets
The world may be a little brighter.
If we could
Listen, respect one another
Love one another, uplift one another
Empathy can become second nature.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jacqueline Jaffee
ISBN: On-Line Transcript Only
Publisher: Duke University
Date (Month/Year): July 13, 2020

Website: https://dukeengage.duke.edu/how-pets-teach-us-empathy-a-poem/

TRANSISTION

"Some people talk to animals. Not many listen though. That's the problem."

And so I vow to listen – to listen and make the following commitment . . . won't you join me? I will . . .

Life Lessons from My Dog by Maryalicia Post

Greet each morning like a welcome surprise,

each family member as if they lite up my world

Delight in what I have to eat, in the freedom to walk

and if confined to old paths

sniff out something interesting each day

If it's bright, relax in a patch of sunlight

If it's dark, curl up in my favourite chair

Yawn and stretch when it suits me

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Bark only when necessary

Be happy for a pat on the back and a soft word

Don't think about yesterday

or tomorrow

Give love and watch it come back

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Maryalicia Post
ISBN: On-Line Transcript Only
Publisher: Your Daily Poem.com
Date (Month/Year): N/A

Website:
http://www.yourdailypoem.com/listpoem.jsp?poem_id=2721

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